



by religion, which is unusual in an area almost exclusively made up of Muslim countries. The Balinese are proud of having preserved their unique Hindu culture and this is seen in the large number of beautiful

temples on the island and numerous festivals and celebrations held. The island is visited by thousands of tourists and although this has led to many changes, the Balinese have sustained a vibrant and fascinating culture.

MARKETS

The colorful Balinese markets are not only a necessity to the people, but also attract large number of tourists eager to buy their beautiful crafts.



ART

Textiles and carvings represent a mark of cultural identity to the Balinese. Their clothes are beautifully designed and famous the world over. Woodcarving is at its best as part of temple and palace architecture in Bali.



MUSIC

A traditional Balinese orchestra is known as the *gamelan*. It is almost completely made up of percussion instruments, such as gongs, cymbals, and xylophones. The Balinese believe that the *gamelan* is of divine origin and the instruments are treated with the greatest respect.

Balinese cremation

The people of Bali see a cremation ceremony as a joyous occasion rather than one of mourning. Hundreds of people carry beautifully decorated towers, sometimes 60 ft (18 m) high, containing the body to the place of cremation. The body is then placed inside a wooden casket and the whole thing, with the decorations, is set alight in order to liberate the soul to a higher world.



An impressive cremation adds greatly to the prestige of a wealthy family, giving occasion for extravagant festivities.

